

INCIDENT RESPONSE REPORT

Azuki Import/Export Trading Co. - Security Breach

CONFIDENTIAL - RESTRICTED DISTRIBUTION

Field	Details
Date of Report	2025-11-20
Severity Level	CRITICAL
Report Status	Contained
Escalated To	CISO / Senior IR Team
Incident ID	INC-2025-1120-001
Analyst	Karanbir Singh

SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

- Attacker gained initial access via RDP using compromised credentials of kenji.sato from IP 88.97.178.12
- Malicious scripts (wupdate.ps1 / WindowsUpdate.bat) were downloaded from C2 server at 78.141.196.6 to automate the attack chain
- Credential dumping tool (mm.exe / Mimikatz) was used to extract logon passwords from LSASS memory
- Sensitive business data was compressed into export-data.zip and exfiltrated via Discord to the attacker
- Backdoor account 'support' was created with Administrator privileges, and all major Windows event logs were wiped to destroy evidence

WHO, WHAT, WHEN, WHERE, WHY, HOW

WHO

Attacker Source IP: 88.97.178.12 (RDP initial access)

C2 Infrastructure: 78.141.196.6:443 (C2 beacon), 78.141.196.6:8080 (payload delivery)

Compromised Account: kenji.sato

Compromised System: AZUKI-SL (IT Admin Workstation)

WHAT

- RDP brute force / credential stuffing against kenji.sato account
- Download and execution of wupdate.ps1 from external C2 server
- Windows Defender disabled via registry exclusions (3 file extensions + Temp folder path)
- Malware staged in C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache

- Scheduled task 'Windows Update Check' created for persistence running svchost.exe from staging directory
- Credential dumping via mm.exe (Mimikatz) using sekurlsa::logonpasswords
- Data collection and compression into export-data.zip
- Exfiltration via Discord
- Backdoor account 'support' added to Administrators group
- Windows event logs (Security, System, Application) cleared to destroy forensic evidence
- Lateral movement to 10.1.0.188 via mstsc.exe

WHEN

Time (UTC)	Event
Nov 19, 2025 - Unknown	Initial RDP connection from 88.97.178.12 as kenji.sato
Nov 20, 2025 12:06 AM	PowerShell opened interactively by kenji.sato
Nov 20, 2025 12:07 AM	wupdate.ps1 downloaded from 78.141.196.6:8080
Nov 20, 2025 12:16 AM	Second payload download attempt
Nov 20, 2025 12:33 AM	wupdate.ps1 executes and spawns child PowerShell (persistence loop)
Nov 20, 2025 12:39 AM	Backdoor account 'support' created and added to Administrators
Nov 20, 2025 12:41 AM	Security, System, Application event logs cleared
Nov 20, 2025 12:45 AM	Staging directory C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache established
Nov 20, 2025 ~1:00 AM	mm.exe (Mimikatz) executed - sekurlsa::logonpasswords
Nov 20, 2025 ~2:00 AM	export-data.zip created and exfiltrated via Discord
Nov 20, 2025 ~5:00 AM	Lateral movement to 10.1.0.188 via mstsc.exe

WHERE

Compromised Host: AZUKI-SL (IT Admin Workstation)

Attacker Entry IP: 88.97.178.12

C2 Server: 78.141.196.6 (port 443 C2, port 8080 payload delivery)

Malware Staging: C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache

Payload Temp Path: C:\Users\KENJI~1\SAT\AppData\Local\Temp\wupdate.ps1

Credential Tool: C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache\mm.exe

Lateral Movement Target: 10.1.0.188

WHY

Root Cause: Externally exposed RDP with weak / previously leaked credentials for kenji.sato. No MFA enforced on RDP access.

Attacker Objective: Corporate espionage — theft of supplier contracts and pricing data (confirmed: competitor undercut Azuki's 6-year contract by exactly 3%)

HOW — Attack Chain

1. RDP access established using kenji.sato credentials from 88.97.178.12
2. WindowsUpdate.bat executed, triggering PowerShell to download wupdate.ps1 from C2 (78.141.196.6:8080)
3. Windows Defender exclusions added via registry (3 extensions + Temp folder) to allow malware to run undetected
4. Staging directory C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache created and hidden using attrib
5. Scheduled task 'Windows Update Check' created pointing to C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache\svchost.exe for persistence
6. C2 beacon established to 78.141.196.6:443 from malicious svchost.exe
7. mm.exe (Mimikatz renamed) executed with sekurlsa::logonpasswords to dump credentials from LSASS
8. Target data collected and compressed into export-data.zip
9. export-data.zip exfiltrated via Discord
10. Backdoor account 'support' created and added to local Administrators group
11. Security, System, Application event logs wiped via wevtutil to destroy evidence
12. Lateral movement to 10.1.0.188 via mstsc.exe (RDP) using dumped credentials

IMPACT ASSESSMENT

- Confidential supplier contracts and pricing data stolen — directly used by competitor
- All three major Windows event logs wiped — significant forensic evidence destroyed
- Active backdoor account 'support' with admin rights remains on system
- Persistent scheduled task survives reboots — attacker retains access mechanism
- Lateral movement to at least one additional internal host (10.1.0.188) — scope potentially wider
- LSASS credential dump — all credentials cached on AZUKI-SL are considered compromised

Risk Level: CRITICAL

RECOMMENDATIONS

IMMEDIATE

- Isolate AZUKI-SL from network immediately if not already done
- Disable and delete backdoor account 'support'
- Reset kenji.sato password and all credentials cached on AZUKI-SL
- Block 78.141.196.6 and 88.97.178.12 at firewall and EDR
- Delete scheduled task 'Windows Update Check'
- Remove C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache directory and all contents
- Scan 10.1.0.188 for signs of compromise immediately

SHORT-TERM (1-7 Days)

- Enforce MFA on all RDP access — this was the root cause entry point
- Restrict RDP access to VPN only or via jump host

- Hunt across all endpoints for wupdate.ps1, mm.exe, export-data.zip, svchost.exe in non-standard paths
- Check Discord traffic logs for other potential exfiltration events
- Audit all local Administrator group members across the environment
- Review Windows Defender exclusions on all endpoints for unauthorized entries

LONG-TERM

- Deploy Privileged Access Workstation (PAW) for IT admin accounts
- Implement LSASS protection (PPL - Protected Process Light) to prevent credential dumping
- Enable Windows Event Log forwarding to SIEM — local log clearing should not destroy all evidence
- Deploy network segmentation to limit lateral movement opportunities
- Conduct adversary simulation exercise to validate detection coverage

APPENDIX

A. Indicators of Compromise

Category	Indicator	Description
Attacker IP	88.97.178.12	RDP initial access source
C2 Server	78.141.196.6:443	Command and control beacon
C2 Server	78.141.196.6:8080	Payload delivery server
Malicious File	wupdate.ps1	PowerShell attack automation script
Malicious File	wupdate.bat	Batch file dropper
Malicious File	WindowsUpdate.bat	Masqueraded bat launcher
Malicious File	mm.exe	Mimikatz renamed credential dumper
Malicious File	export-data.zip	Data exfiltration archive
Malicious Path	C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache	Malware staging directory
Malicious Path	C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache\svchost.exe	Malicious executable (persistence)
Account	support	Backdoor local admin account created by attacker
Scheduled Task	Windows Update Check	Persistence mechanism
Lateral Target	10.1.0.188	Secondary compromised host
Exfil Channel	Discord	Cloud service abused for data exfiltration

B. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Tactic	Technique	ID	Evidence
Initial Access	Remote Desktop Protocol	T1021.001	RDP from 88.97.178.12 as kenji.sato
Execution	PowerShell	T1059.001	wupdate.ps1 executed with -ExecutionPolicy Bypass
Execution	Command & Scripting: Batch	T1059.003	WindowsUpdate.bat launcher
Persistence	Scheduled Task	T1053.005	'Windows Update Check' task created
Defense Evasion	Impair Defenses: Disable AV	T1562.001	Registry exclusions added to Defender
Defense Evasion	Masquerading	T1036	mm.exe (Mimikatz), svchost.exe in non-standard path
Defense Evasion	Clear Windows Event Logs	T1070.001	wevtutil cl Security/System/Application
Defense Evasion	Hidden Files/Directories	T1564.001	attrib used on staging directory
Credential Access	LSASS Memory Dump	T1003.001	mm.exe sekurlsa::logonpasswords
Discovery	Network Neighbor Discovery	T1016	ARP.EXE -a executed
Collection	Archive Collected Data	T1560.001	export-data.zip created
C2	Ingress Tool Transfer	T1105	certutil.exe used to download payloads
Exfiltration	Exfiltration Over Web Service	T1567	Data sent via Discord
Lateral Movement	Remote Desktop Protocol	T1021.001	mstsc.exe to 10.1.0.188
Persistence	Create Local Account	T1136.001	'support' account added to Administrators

C. Investigation Timeline

Time (UTC)	Event	Details
Nov 20 12:06 AM	Interactive PowerShell opened	kenji.sato spawns powershell.exe from explorer.exe
Nov 20 12:07 AM	C2 payload download #1	wupdate.ps1 pulled from 78.141.196.6:8080 via PowerShell IWR
Nov 20 12:07 AM	Payload execution	wupdate.ps1 executed with -WindowStyle Hidden
Nov 20 12:16 AM	C2 payload download #2	Second download attempt from Downloads\WindowsUpdate.bat
Nov 20 12:19 AM	C2 payload download #3	Third download attempt
Nov 20 12:33 AM	Persistence loop	powershell.exe spawns child powershell.exe running wupdate.ps1
Nov 20 12:39 AM	Backdoor account created	net.exe user support /add + localgroup Administrators support /add

Time (UTC)	Event	Details
Nov 20 12:41 AM	Log clearing	wevtutil cl Security, System, Application
Nov 20 12:45 AM	Staging directory active	C:\ProgramData\WindowsCache in use
Nov 20 ~1:00 AM	Credential dumping	mm.exe sekurlsa::logonpasswords executed
Nov 20 ~2:00 AM	Data exfiltration	export-data.zip sent via Discord
Nov 20 2:54 AM	Audit policy recon	20x auditpol.exe queries in seconds
Nov 20 ~5:00 AM	Lateral movement	mstsc.exe connecting to 10.1.0.188

E. Key Investigation Queries

Query 1: Identify malicious PowerShell download activity

```
DeviceProcessEvents | where DeviceName == "azuki-sl" | where FileName == "powershell.exe" | where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("http://", "Invoke-WebRequest", "-OutFile")
```

Result: Identified wupdate.ps1 download from 78.141.196.6:8080 by kenji.sato at 12:07 AM

Query 2: Detect event log clearing

```
DeviceProcessEvents | where FileName == "wevtutil.exe" | where ProcessCommandLine contains "cl "
```

Result: Security log cleared first at 12:41 AM, followed by System and Application

Query 3: Backdoor account creation

```
DeviceProcessEvents | where FileName in ("net.exe", "net1.exe") | where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("/add", "Administrators")
```

Result: Account 'support' created and added to Administrators at 12:39 AM

Query 4: Defender exclusion registry modifications

```
DeviceRegistryEvents | where RegistryKey contains "Windows Defender\\Exclusions" | where ActionType == "RegistryValueSet"
```

Result: 3 file extensions excluded + C:\Users\KENJI~1.SAT\AppData\Local\Temp path excluded

Query 5: C2 network connections

```
DeviceNetworkEvents | where DeviceName == "azuki-sl" | where RemoteIP == "78.141.196.6" | project TimeGenerated, InitiatingProcessFileName, RemoteIP, RemotePort
```

Result: C2 beacon on port 443, payload delivery on port 8080